ONLINE SCAMS PLANNING

Research Title: Developing Multilingual South African Context Online Cybersecurity Modules For Students

Module : Online Scams

Module Developers:

Planning Stage : 16 July – 30 July 2026

Purpose

- To address South African Relevant threats and help students understand how cyber threats occur and how users can respond appropriately
- Help students recognise,understand and respond to common online scams, particularly Whatsapp, SMS and email scams

Module Topics

- Introduction to Online Scams
- Whatsapp Scams
- SMS Scams
- Email Scams
- How Scammers Manipulate Victims
- Responding to a Scam

Learning Outcomes

1. Define an online scam and explain how scammers target users.
2. Identify common warning signs of WhatsApp, SMS and email scams.
3. Distinguish between legitimate and suspicious online messages.
4. Explain common manipulation techniques used by scammers.
5. Demonstrate appropriate responses to suspicious online messages.
6. Apply cybersecurity practices to reduce their risk of becoming victims of online scams

Learning Approach

A. Short Topic Explanation:

Introduce the concept using small amount of text

B. Real World Example:

Show realistic SA scam

C. Interactive Scenario:

Give students simulated situation and see what they would do

D. Immediate feedback:

Explain why their answer is correct or incorrect

E. Short activity/Quiz:

Test if they understood the concept

Interactive Scenarios

The module will use simulated scenarios to demonstrate how online scams occur and how scammers attempt to manipulate users. The scenarios will focus on WhatsApp, SMS, and email scams, as identified in the research proposal.

SCENARIO 1: WHATSAPP

Students will be presented with a simulated WhatsApp conversation in which a scammer attempts to persuade the user to click a link, provide information, or take another unsafe action. Students will be asked to identify whether the message is suspicious and select the safest response

SCENARIO 2: SMS

Students will be presented with a simulated SMS message containing characteristics commonly associated with scams, such as urgency, suspicious links, or requests for information. Students will identify the warning signs and determine the appropriate response

SCENARIO 3: EMAIL

Students will be presented with a simulated suspicious email. Students will analyse the sender information, message content, links, attachments, and requests made in the email before deciding whether it should be trusted or treated as a scam

Scam Warning Signs

Students will be taught to identify common warning signs that may indicate that a WhatsApp message, SMS, or email is a scam. The module will focus on the following indicators:

- Urgent or threatening requests that pressure the user to act immediately.
- Suspicious or unexpected links.

- Requests for personal or sensitive information.
- Impersonation of organisations, companies, individuals, or other trusted entities.
- Unexpected messages or offers.
- Promises of prizes, rewards, or financial benefits.
- Unusual sender information or communication details

AI-Assisted Learning Content

AI-assisted content will be incorporated to support the development of realistic and engaging learning scenarios. The use of AI will focus on supporting learning activities rather than replacing the instructional content.

Multilingual Support

The Online Scams module will support multilingual accessibility through selected South African languages identified in the research proposal: isiZulu, Sepedi, and Xitsonga. English will be used as the primary version, with selected learning content adapted into the three languages.

The following content will be considered for multilingual adaptation:

- Key cybersecurity concepts and terms
- Instructions for learning activities
- Simulated scam scenarios
- Activity questions and response options
- Assessment questions

Module Planning Summary

The Online Scams module will combine short explanations, South African-context examples, interactive scenarios, practical activities, AI-assisted learning content, multilingual support, and assessment. The design is intended to help students recognise common online scams, understand how scammers manipulate users, and apply appropriate responses to suspicious online communications.